

PROPERTY PREP GUIDE

The Pre-Shoot Checklist

The difference between a listing that photographs well and one that doesn't is almost never the house — it's the ninety minutes of prep before the camera comes out. **Work this list and your shoot runs on schedule, your photos need less retouching, and your listing goes live sooner.**

48 Hours Before

EXTERIOR & ACCESS

- ☐ Confirm access — lockbox code, or who is meeting the crew on site
- ☐ Lawn mowed and edged, clippings cleared off walkways and drive
- ☐ Shrubs trimmed back from windows and the front entry
- ☐ Trash and recycling bins moved out of sight — garage or side yard
- ☐ Cars off the driveway and the street directly in front — including the neighbors', if they'll move them
- ☐ Pool cleaned, cover off, hoses and equipment stowed
- ☐ Patio furniture arranged, cushions out, grill covered or cleaned
- ☐ Book any small repairs now — chipped paint, torn screens, loose railings

24 Hours Before

DECLUTTER & DEPERSONALIZE

- ☐ Replace every burnt-out bulb — and match the color temperature room to room
- ☐ Family photos, diplomas, mail, and medications put away
- ☐ Kitchen counters cleared to one or two accent pieces maximum
- ☐ Bathroom counters completely clear — fresh towels, lids down
- ☐ Refrigerator stripped of magnets, papers, and artwork
- ☐ Pet bowls, beds, crates, litter boxes, and toys stored out of frame
- ☐ Cords, chargers, and remotes hidden
- ☐ Beds made with clean, wrinkle-free linens
- ☐ Closets tidied and floors cleared — buyers open them, and so does the camera

The single biggest fix we make in post: mismatched bulbs. One warm bulb beside two cool ones turns a clean white kitchen green on camera, and correcting it costs editing time on every frame of the room. Swapping four bulbs the day before costs about twelve dollars.

Morning Of

FINAL PASS

- ☐ Every blind and curtain open, slats angled level
- ☐ Every light on — including closets, under-cabinet, and lamps
- ☐ Ceiling fans off — they blur badly on video
- ☐ Televisions off and screens wiped free of dust
- ☐ Floors vacuumed, hard surfaces mopped and dry
- ☐ Windows and mirrors spot-cleaned at eye level
- ☐ Toilet lids down, shower doors squeegeed clear
- ☐ Kitchen sink empty, dry, and wiped
- ☐ Thermostat set comfortable — the crew will be on site two to three hours

Timing the light

Light does more for a property than any amount of retouching. If you can control only one variable, control when we shoot.

SHOT	BEST WINDOW
Interiors	Mid-morning or mid-afternoon — soft, indirect light with no hard shadow across the floors
Exteriors, front-facing	Afternoon, once the sun has come around to the front of the house
Exteriors, rear or west-facing	Morning, before the sun moves behind the roofline
Golden hour	The ninety minutes before sunset — best light of the day for hero exteriors
Twilight	Begins twenty minutes before sunset and lasts about thirty. One window, no second chance
Drone	Clear skies and wind under 20 mph — we monitor and will call it if conditions turn

What actually slows a shoot down

Every one of these has cost a shoot an hour or forced a return visit. They are all avoidable with a phone call the day before.

- ✗ Nobody on site with access
- ✗ Pets loose in the house
- ✗ Cars that nobody can move
- ✗ Staging still in progress on arrival
- ✗ Contractors still working on site
- ✗ Owner following the crew room to room

We can handle all of it.

Our monthly retainer clients get shoot coordination included — we confirm access, walk the prep list with the seller, and time the light so you never think about any of this.

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